To recap, Tantra mostly had subaltern, non-Vedic roots and was associated with fertility cults, amorous motifs and symbols, magic and alchemy, sexo-yogic practices, and a higher status for women. Across India from the mid-first millennium CE, princes, state officials, landed aristocrats, wealthy merchants, clergy, artists and others began embracing new sects that mixed Tantra with Puranic beliefs.

Tantra soon furnished, or at least amplified, a world view in which sex and religion were not divergent pursuits. In Tantra, *sex was a path to the divine* (or Brahman). Its magical use of sex to propitiate the gods became a shortcut to moksha—competing directly with the moksha of orthodox Hindus and Buddhists that required the renouncing of sex. Tantra effectively normalized the idea of yogis, acharyas, and ascetics— male and female—restlessly fiddling with their erogenous zones to attain 'union with the divine' (never mind that many were likely just having a jolly good time).

The temple-building elites seamlessly fused the magico-religious aspects of Tantric sex with their sex-positive culture. Tantra's appeal and symbols, alongside Puranic beliefs, already ran deep with the masses. In this milieu, far from being dissonant, erotica and temple walls would have seemed naturally harmonious. The result: erotic art on temple walls.

Desai, however, clarifies that for the most part, this erotic art doesn't directly show Tantric sexual rituals, which were meant to be secretive; it is art influenced by Tantra but without much functional relation to it. 'A further consequence of Tantra,' she adds, was an 'attitude of permissiveness towards sex' and a 'veneration of sex in religious life in contrast to the condemnatory attitude of orthodox Hindu and early Buddhist traditions'.[49]

Once it began, other mundane factors likely drove more erotica on temple walls. For one, sex likely brought out the numbers. Temples competed with each other for visitors, prestige and funds, so they stood to gain by literally amping up their sex appeal. An Orissan *Shilpa Shastra* text of the day, a canon of architecture, seems to recognize that religion was also entertainment, and it mentions the use of sexual depictions in temple art for the 'delight of the people'.[50] Once Tantra normalized the mixing of sex with religion, how hard would it have been to conclude that having more sexual images was the way to delight more people? As a popular art motif, it also